

Why Would a Good God Create a World Knowing Many Would Be Lost?

Wrestling with One of Christianity's Most Difficult Questions

There are objections to Christianity that can be answered relatively simply. Others reach so deeply into the character and purposes of God that Christians should approach them with both conviction and humility.

One of the most difficult is this:

If God knew before He created humanity that mankind would fall into sin, that untold suffering would follow, and that many people would ultimately reject Him and face judgment, why did He create humanity at all?

The question becomes even more troubling when we consider the enormous differences in human circumstances. One person is born into a Christian family, grows up hearing the gospel, attends church, owns several Bibles, and hears about Jesus Christ throughout his life. Another is born into a Hindu family in India. Another grows up Buddhist. Another is raised within Islam. Another grows up in an atheistic culture. Another is raised within a cult that seriously distorts Christianity. Still another may live and die having heard little or nothing that could reasonably be called a clear presentation of the gospel.

If God determined when and where people would be born, knew beforehand what they would believe, and knew their eternal destiny before creating them, has the game somehow been rigged from the beginning? And if God knew that many would be lost, wouldn't it have been better simply not to create them?

These are not foolish questions. They touch the doctrines of creation, God's foreknowledge, human freedom, sin, divine justice, salvation, hell, and ultimately the character of God Himself. Christianity should not be afraid of them.

Unless otherwise noted, all Scripture quotations are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB).

The Question Behind All the Other Questions

Before discussing hell, salvation, other religions, or human freedom, we should identify the deepest objection. It is not simply, **“Why does God send people to hell?”**

The deeper question is:

“Why would a perfectly loving God create people whom He already knew would ultimately be lost?”

That is considerably harder.

Suppose God knows everything that will ever happen. Before creating the universe, He therefore knows Adam will fall. He knows Cain will murder Abel. He knows every war that will be fought, every child who will suffer, every murder, betrayal, disease, famine, persecution, and atrocity of human history. And He knows every person who will ultimately receive or reject His offer of salvation.

Yet He creates anyway.

Why?

Scripture never gives us a single verse explaining everything that entered God's eternal purpose in choosing to create. Therefore, Christians should resist giving simplistic answers where Scripture itself leaves mystery. But Scripture does reveal enough about God's character and purposes to establish several important truths.

1. Before We Judge God, We Must Consider the Standard by Which We Judge Him

Part I — Do We Know Enough to Declare God's Decision Unjust?

The objection at the heart of this paper is serious. If God knew before creating humanity that Adam and Eve would fall, that suffering and death would enter the world, that countless people would reject Him, and that many would ultimately be lost, then why create at all?

Was creation, in some sense, **rigged from the beginning?**

That question deserves more than a quick theological answer because it raises a serious concern about the character and justice of God. If God knowingly created humanity while fully aware of everything that would follow, we naturally have to ask how that decision can be reconciled with His perfect goodness. But before concluding that God's decision was unjust, we should ask whether we know enough about His purposes to say that He could have had no good reason for creating.

Scripture begins by making an extraordinary claim about the character of God. Abraham asked:

“Will not the Judge of all the earth do what is right?”
— Genesis 18:25

Moses later declared:

“He is the Rock, His work is perfect; all His ways are just. A God of faithfulness without injustice, righteous and upright is He.”
— Deuteronomy 32:4

Christianity therefore does not merely claim that God is powerful enough to do whatever He chooses. **It claims that God is perfectly righteous, perfectly just, and perfectly good.**

That does not mean we should avoid difficult questions about His actions. Scripture itself is filled with people asking God difficult questions. Abraham questioned Him. Job struggled to understand Him. Habakkuk asked why God permitted evil and injustice. The Psalms repeatedly contain cries of confusion, grief, and anguish. God is not threatened by honest questions.

But there is an important difference between asking:

“Why would a good God do this?”

and declaring:

“A good God could have no morally sufficient reason for doing this.”

The first is a question seeking understanding. The second is a conclusion about the total purposes of God. **That distinction matters because our knowledge is extraordinarily limited compared with the knowledge such a conclusion would require.**

We see only a small portion of human history. We do not know every consequence of every life, every relationship, every act of love, every act of suffering, every redemption, or every eternal consequence flowing from God's decision to create. We certainly do not possess God's knowledge of the completed story. Therefore, there is an enormous difference between saying:

“I do not fully understand why God chose to create a world in which He knew rebellion would occur,”

and saying:

“A perfectly good God could have no morally sufficient reason for creating such a world.”

The first is intellectual humility; the second requires knowledge we do not possess. This does not answer the question of why God created, nor should mystery be used as an excuse to avoid the question. **Mystery is not evidence of injustice.** Not knowing God's complete reason for an action is not the same as demonstrating that no good reason exists.

Part II — What Makes Right and Wrong Objectively Real?

But the charge that creation was “rigged” raises another question—one that goes even deeper. When we say that God was **wrong** to create humanity knowing what would happen, what exactly do we mean by *wrong*?

There is an important irony here. **The person putting God on trial is often admitting—perhaps without realizing it—that there is a real moral standard by which even the concept of God can be judged.**

If the objection is simply, “I do not like what God did,” then we are describing a personal reaction. We may find God’s decision troubling. We may wish He had created differently. We may even say that, if the decision had been ours, we would not have created at all. But that is very different from saying:

“God was morally wrong to create.”

The word *wrong* carries enormous weight. It assumes that some things are truly right and others truly wrong—not merely because an individual dislikes them, a culture condemns them, or a majority votes against them, but because there is a real distinction between good and evil, justice and injustice. And once we make that claim, another question immediately arises:

What makes that moral standard objectively true?

If morality is ultimately nothing more than personal preference, cultural convention, social consensus, or the product of human biological and social development, then we can certainly say, **“I do not like the world Christianity says God created.”** But that is very different from saying, **“God was objectively wrong to create it.”** The second statement requires something more than personal disapproval. It requires a moral standard that remains true regardless of what I think, what you think, what a particular culture believes, or what a majority decides.

Christianity does not deny the existence of such a standard. Quite the opposite. Christianity insists that good and evil are real, justice and injustice are real, and God’s actions have genuine moral significance. The deeper question is:

Where does that moral reality come from?

Christianity has an answer. Goodness is not an arbitrary set of rules God invented, as though something became good merely because God decided to call it good. Neither is goodness a higher law existing above God to which He must submit. **Goodness is rooted in the character of God Himself.**

God does not merely *do* what is good. He is good. Justice is not foreign to His nature, and righteousness is not a standard imposed upon Him from somewhere else. They are expressions of who He is. Scripture declares:

“For the LORD is righteous; He loves justice.”
— Psalm 11:7

And:

“Righteousness and justice are the foundation of Your throne; loving devotion and faithfulness go before You.”
— Psalm 89:14

This does not mean that raising a moral objection against Christianity somehow proves Christianity to be true. Nor does it prevent someone from challenging Christianity on its own terms: **“If Christianity says God is perfectly good, then explain how His decision to create is consistent with that goodness.”** That is a legitimate challenge. In fact, much of the remainder of this paper is devoted to answering it.

But there is a difference between asking Christianity to demonstrate that its understanding of God is morally consistent and claiming that God can be condemned by an objective moral standard without asking what makes that standard objectively true. The Christian is not arguing that unbelievers cannot recognize good and evil. Clearly they can. The question is more fundamental:

What makes good actually good and evil actually evil, regardless of what any individual or society happens to believe?

So the accusation that creation was “rigged” ultimately presents questions for both sides. The Christian must explain how God's decision to create—knowing beforehand the Fall, human suffering, rejection, and judgment—can be reconciled with His perfect goodness. But the person accusing God of injustice must also consider the foundation upon which that accusation rests.

When you put God on trial for being unjust, you are appealing to a real standard of justice. Before we put God in the defendant's chair, we should ask what makes that standard objectively true—and whether the Christian worldview actually provides the foundation for the very moral judgment being used against it.

Neither question should be avoided, and neither can be answered merely by saying, **“I would have done things differently.”** The question before us is much larger than that. It is whether the God who knew the end from the beginning could have a good and sufficient purpose for creating humanity despite everything He knew would follow—and whether the biblical story gives us sufficient reason to trust His character even when we cannot yet see everything that He sees.

2. God's Sovereignty, Foreknowledge, and Human Responsibility

Here we encounter one of the great mysteries underlying this entire question. **It is difficult to separate God's perfect foreknowledge from His sovereign will.** The God of Scripture does not merely observe history in advance as though He were a spectator. He is sovereign over history and accomplishes His purposes within it.

Yet Scripture just as clearly treats human beings as morally responsible for what they choose and do.

Perhaps the clearest example is the crucifixion of Jesus Christ. Peter declares:

“He was delivered up by God's set plan and foreknowledge, and you, by the hands of the lawless, put Him to death by nailing Him to the cross.”

— Acts 2:23

Notice that Peter does not choose between God's sovereignty and human responsibility. The crucifixion occurred according to **God's set plan and foreknowledge**. Yet those who crucified Jesus were still described as **lawless** and held responsible for what they had done.

The same truth appears again when the believers pray concerning Herod, Pontius Pilate, the Gentiles, and the people of Israel who opposed Jesus:

“They carried out what Your hand and will had decided beforehand would happen.”

— Acts 4:28

Here the paradox becomes even more striking. The death of Christ occurred according to God's sovereign purpose, yet Judas, Pilate, Herod, the religious leaders, and those who demanded His crucifixion were not treated as innocent instruments with no responsibility for their actions.

Scripture therefore places two truths before us:

God is sovereign over history.

Human beings are responsible for their choices.

How those truths fit together perfectly is one of the mysteries Christians have debated for centuries. We do not need to solve that entire theological question in order to address the issue before us.

What we should not do is assume that because God knew beforehand that Adam would fall—or that another person would reject Him—God's knowledge somehow made that person's rebellion morally meaningless.

God knew. God remained sovereign. And the creature remained responsible.

That tension will appear repeatedly throughout this discussion. Rather than eliminating either side to make the problem easier, we should allow Scripture to maintain both.

3. Creation Was Not a Trap

If God created Adam and Eve without telling them what obedience required, their rebellion might appear more like entrapment. But that is not the biblical account. God gave humanity life, provision, fellowship, purpose, and freedom. He also gave a clear command.

The serpent's strategy was not to expose some hidden trap God had constructed. His strategy was to persuade humanity to distrust God's goodness:

“Did God really say...?”

— Genesis 3:1

That question remains near the center of humanity's rebellion. The temptation was ultimately not merely about eating forbidden fruit. It was about whether God could be trusted. The serpent suggested that God was withholding something good from humanity. Humanity believed the creature rather than the Creator, and the consequences entered creation.

4. But Why Permit the Possibility of the Fall?

Here the question becomes more difficult. Why create beings capable of rebellion?

One common Christian answer is freedom. Love that is compelled is not love in the fullest relational sense. If God desired creatures capable of genuine relationship, trust, obedience, and love, then the ability to respond to God carries with it the possibility of rejecting Him. A world populated by creatures incapable of doing anything except what they were programmed to do might contain obedience, but it would not contain moral freedom in the same sense.

This provides a plausible explanation for why God might permit the possibility of evil, but we should recognize its limits. It explains why freedom might include the possibility of rebellion. It does not completely explain why God created this particular world knowing rebellion would actually occur.

At that point the question moves beyond freedom into the larger purposes of God.

5. The Cross Was Not God's Emergency Plan

One of the greatest misunderstandings of Christianity is imagining the biblical story as though God created humanity, humanity unexpectedly ruined everything, and God then devised the cross as an emergency rescue plan.

Scripture presents something far greater.

Paul writes:

“For He chose us in Him before the foundation of the world to be holy and blameless in His presence.”

— Ephesians 1:4

Peter describes Christ as *“chosen before the foundation of the world, but was revealed in these last times for your sake”* (1 Peter 1:20).

Redemption therefore reaches back into the eternal purposes of God—before Bethlehem, before Abraham, before Noah, before Adam, before creation itself.

God knew the cost. And He created anyway.

That changes the picture dramatically. God did not create a dangerous experiment, watch humanity destroy itself, and then observe the tragedy from the safety of heaven. The Creator entered His creation. The Judge stepped into the place of the judged. The One against whom humanity rebelled bore the cost of reconciliation Himself.

At Calvary, Christianity makes an astonishing claim: **The God who knew beforehand what human rebellion would cost chose to create knowing that He Himself would bear that cost.**

6. Does God Create Some People Specifically for Hell?

As we have already seen, Scripture holds God's sovereignty and human responsibility together. But another question remains: **Does God's sovereignty mean that He creates certain people because He desires their condemnation?**

Peter writes:

“The Lord is not slow to fulfill His promise as some understand slowness, but is patient with you, not wanting anyone to perish, but everyone to come to repentance.”
— 2 Peter 3:9

That statement is enormously important to this question. **God's revealed desire is that sinners repent rather than perish.** Yet the very existence of judgment demonstrates that what God desires for human beings does not mean that every human being will ultimately receive it.

This does not mean that God's sovereign purposes can somehow be defeated by human beings. Rather, Scripture itself holds together truths we may have difficulty completely reconciling: God remains sovereign, while at the same time He genuinely calls sinners to repentance, commands them to respond, and holds them responsible for their response.

Jesus' lament over Jerusalem makes that tension especially clear:

“How often I have longed to gather your children together, as a hen gathers her chicks under her wings, but you were unwilling!”
— Matthew 23:37

Notice the two sides of the statement: **“I have longed...”** and **“...but you were unwilling.”** Christ's desire to gather them was genuine. Their unwillingness was also genuine.

This is important because **God's judgment of sin should never be confused with a desire to see sinners perish.** Judgment is an expression of God's justice, but His revealed call to sinners is:

Turn and live.

He says through Ezekiel:

“As surely as I live, declares the Lord GOD, I take no pleasure in the death of the wicked, but rather that the wicked should turn from their ways and live.”

— Ezekiel 33:11

Therefore, when we ask whether God creates certain people specifically because He wants them to go to hell, the biblical evidence points in the opposite direction. God knows beforehand that **many will reject Him, but foreknowledge of their rejection should not be confused with desire for their destruction.**

God's sovereignty is real. Human responsibility is real. God's judgment is real. Yet so is His revealed desire that sinners repent and live.

We may not fully understand how all of these truths fit together, but we should not answer the difficulty by denying something Scripture states plainly:

God takes no pleasure in the death of the wicked. He calls sinners to repentance and life.

7. What About Those Who Have Never Had the Same Opportunity to Hear?

This may be one of the strongest objections to the Christian understanding of salvation because it confronts us with an undeniable reality: **people are not born with equal exposure to the gospel.**

Imagine two children. One is born into a Christian household in Oklahoma. From childhood he hears about Jesus Christ. He attends church. He has Christian relatives. Bibles are readily available. By adulthood he may have heard the gospel hundreds or even thousands of times.

Another child is born thousands of miles away into a deeply Hindu community. His parents are Hindu. His grandparents are Hindu. His friends are Hindu. The people he loves and trusts teach him from childhood to understand God, life, death, and eternity through Hindu beliefs. Christianity may seem to him every bit as foreign as Hinduism seems to the Christian child in Oklahoma.

Can we honestly say these two people have received identical opportunities to hear and understand the gospel?

No. They have not.

And that creates a much harder question: **If God knew where each person would be born, knew what each would be taught, and knew how powerfully family and culture would shape what each person believed, how can His final judgment be perfectly fair?**

We should not answer that question by pretending those differences do not matter. **But neither should we assume that unequal circumstances produce an unequal or uninformed judgment. Scripture repeatedly emphasizes that God judges impartially and with knowledge far beyond our own.**

Paul writes:

“God will repay each one according to his deeds.”
— Romans 2:6

Then he states the principle plainly:

“For God does not show favoritism.”
— Romans 2:11

And later in the same chapter, Paul says that God will *“judge men's secrets through Christ Jesus”* (Romans 2:16).

Taken together, these statements tell us something extremely important. **God's judgment is individual, impartial, and based upon knowledge that reaches even to the secrets of the human heart.**

Human beings cannot judge that way. We see where a person was born, what religion he professes, what he says, and perhaps something of how he has lived. But we cannot see completely what he was taught, what he understood, what opportunities he actually received, what misconceptions he inherited, what truth reached him, what he did with that truth, or what was taking place within his heart.

God can.

Scripture repeatedly distinguishes God's knowledge from ours:

“Man looks at the outward appearance, but the LORD looks at the heart.”
— 1 Samuel 16:7

And when Peter entered the home of Cornelius, a Gentile whom God was preparing to hear the gospel, Peter declared:

“I now truly understand that God does not show favoritism, but welcomes those from every nation who fear Him and do what is right.”
— Acts 10:34–35

Cornelius is especially significant because God did not leave him with the limited revelation he possessed. God sent Peter to him with the message of Jesus Christ. We will return to that remarkable account later, but here the principle is important: **nationality, geography, and religious background do not place anyone beyond either God's knowledge or His reach.**

This does **not** mean that Hinduism, Buddhism, Islam, Christianity, and every other religion are equally valid paths to God. Scripture does not permit that conclusion. Jesus Christ remains the only Savior.

Nor does Scripture tell us precisely how God will judge every person who lived and died without hearing a clear presentation of the gospel. **It does not, and we should not claim knowledge God has not given us.**

What Scripture does tell us is significant. God does not judge people in ignorance of their circumstances. He knows what each person was taught, what opportunities each person received, what truth reached him, what barriers stood in his way, and how he responded to the light he was given.

Therefore, the difference between the child raised in Oklahoma and the child raised in a Hindu community is not information missing from God's judgment. **It is part of the information known perfectly by the Judge.**

Scripture therefore does not teach that everyone receives identical opportunities or identical amounts of revelation. Clearly, they do not. But it does teach something essential to the question before us:

God shows no favoritism. He sees the heart. He knows what is hidden from us. And He judges every person with perfect knowledge.

Whatever differences exist in human circumstances, perfect justice requires that every person be judged perfectly and impartially in light of everything God knows about that person—and God alone possesses that knowledge.

We are not told enough to pronounce the eternal destiny of every person who lived and died without hearing a clear presentation of the gospel. But we are told enough to reject the conclusion that such a person will be judged carelessly, ignorantly, or unfairly.

Scripture gives us a firm foundation:

God knows perfectly. God judges impartially. God judges righteously. And God will wrong no one.

The question, then, is not whether everyone receives the same amount of revelation. Clearly, they do not. The deeper question is whether unequal circumstances prevent a perfectly knowledgeable and perfectly righteous God from rendering perfect judgment.

The biblical evidence gives us powerful reasons to trust that He will.

8. God Has Not Left Humanity Without Witness

Paul teaches in Romans 1 that creation itself reveals something about God:

“For since the creation of the world God's invisible qualities, His eternal power and divine nature, have been clearly seen, being understood from His workmanship.”

— Romans 1:20

Creation does not tell someone the entire gospel. The stars do not explain the crucifixion, and a mountain does not explain justification by faith. But creation bears witness that reality points beyond itself toward a Creator.

Romans 2 adds another dimension: conscience. Human beings possess a moral awareness that bears witness internally, even though conscience can be distorted, suppressed, or wrongly trained.

God therefore has witnesses both outside and inside humanity: **creation around us and conscience within us**. Neither constitutes the full revelation of the gospel, but neither is insignificant.

Paul adds a third consideration while speaking in Athens to people immersed in pagan religion:

“From one man He made every nation of men, that they should inhabit the whole earth; and He determined their appointed times and the boundaries of their lands.”

— Acts 17:26

Then Paul explains something about God's purpose:

“God intended that they would seek Him and perhaps reach out for Him and find Him, though He is not far from each one of us.”

— Acts 17:27

The God who determines the times and places of human existence is therefore not portrayed as deliberately hiding Himself so people cannot find Him. Creation bears witness. Conscience bears witness. And God's providence places human beings within history with the stated purpose that they might seek Him.

This does not give us the full gospel apart from Christ, nor does it answer every question concerning those who never hear His name. But it challenges the picture of God intentionally making Himself impossible to find and then condemning people for failing to accomplish the impossible.

And God's witness to humanity does not end with creation and conscience. **Throughout the Scarlet Thread of Redemption, God repeatedly reaches into human history to make Himself**

known. He seeks Adam after the Fall, calls Abraham out of paganism, reveals Himself to Israel, sends His prophets to a rebellious people, and ultimately enters human history in Jesus Christ. The biblical story is not primarily the story of humanity struggling to find a hidden God. **It is the story of God revealing Himself and seeking the lost.** We will return to this more fully in Section 10.

9. But Isn't Salvation Only Through Jesus Christ?

Yes. The New Testament is emphatic on this point.

Jesus declares:

“I am the way and the truth and the life. No one comes to the Father except through Me.”
— John 14:6

Peter likewise says:

“Salvation exists in no one else, for there is no other name under heaven given to men by which we must be saved.”
— Acts 4:12

Christianity therefore cannot say that Hinduism, Buddhism, Islam, Christianity, and every other religion are simply different roads leading to the same destination. That would contradict the claims of Christ Himself.

But another question remains: **What about the person who never receives a clear presentation of the gospel or who has been taught a distorted understanding of Jesus Christ from childhood?**

Scripture does not give us enough information to explain precisely how God deals with every such circumstance, and we should resist answering questions God has not fully answered. What Scripture does make unmistakably clear is that **salvation, wherever it is found, is found only through Jesus Christ.** No one is saved because another religion provides an alternative path to God. If anyone is saved, that salvation is possible only because of the person and saving work of Jesus Christ.

We therefore do not need to decide the eternal destiny of every hypothetical person. We can affirm what Scripture clearly reveals while refusing to speculate where it remains silent:

Jesus Christ is the only Savior, and the God who judges every human being will judge with perfect knowledge and perfect justice.

The unanswered cases belong not in our hands, but in His.

10. Could Someone Honestly Seek God and Be Rejected Because of Geography?

Before imagining someone desperately searching for God and being unable to find Him, we should remember one of the great truths revealed by the entire *Scarlet Thread of Redemption*:

Christianity is not primarily the story of humanity searching for God. It is the story of God searching for us.

That pattern begins almost as soon as sin enters the world. After Adam and Eve rebel, they do not go searching for God. They hide from Him. Yet God enters the garden and calls to Adam:

“Where are you?”
— Genesis 3:9

That question echoes throughout the biblical story. God calls Abraham out of paganism. He hears Israel's cries in Egypt and comes down to deliver them. He sends prophets to a rebellious people who repeatedly turn away from Him. And finally, He enters human history in Jesus Christ.

Jesus describes His mission in unmistakable terms:

“For the Son of Man came to seek and to save the lost.”
— Luke 19:10

That changes how we should think about the person born in a distant country surrounded by Hinduism, Buddhism, Islam, atheism, or another belief system. The ultimate question is not simply whether that person, by his own wisdom and determination, can search through the religions of the world until he discovers the correct one.

The greater question is whether God is capable of reaching him.

Geography is not an obstacle to God. Culture is not an obstacle to God. A false religion is not an obstacle beyond God's ability to penetrate.

We see a remarkable biblical example in Cornelius. He was a Gentile who feared God and sought Him, but he did not yet understand the gospel of Jesus Christ. God did not leave him there. An angel directed Cornelius to send for Peter, while God simultaneously prepared Peter through a vision to go to him (Acts 10:1–20). Peter then entered Cornelius's home and proclaimed Jesus Christ to him and his household.

This account does not tell us precisely how God deals with every person throughout history who has never heard the gospel, and we should not make it say more than it does. But it demonstrates something important:

Distance, culture, and a person's present lack of knowledge are not barriers to God's ability to bring truth to someone He is drawing.

As we have already seen in Acts 17, the God who determines where people live is **“not far from each one of us.”**

The biblical story repeatedly portrays God seeking, calling, warning, revealing, and inviting. This does not mean that every unbeliever consciously thinks, *“I hate God and deliberately choose hell.”* Human unbelief is far more complicated than that. Upbringing, culture, knowledge, deception, and opportunity all matter, as we have already seen.

Nor should we presume that we can look into the skeptic's heart and determine why he does not believe. What appears to us as rejection may involve confusion, inadequate understanding, religious distortion, personal suffering, insufficient opportunity, resistance to truth, or factors known perfectly only to God. We cannot make that judgment from the outside. **But God can.** He alone knows whether a person genuinely sought truth, what opportunities that person actually received, what barriers stood in the way, and how that person responded to the light he was given.

But neither does Scripture present final judgment as God turning away people who genuinely desire reconciliation with Him.

Jesus Himself said:

“Ask, and it will be given to you; seek, and you will find; knock, and the door will be opened to you. For everyone who asks receives; he who seeks finds; and to him who knocks, the door will be opened.”

— Matthew 7:7–8

This does not mean that every honest seeker immediately arrives at complete theological understanding. But it does reveal something important about the character of God: **He does not turn away those who sincerely seek Him.**

And even more importantly, God seeks the lost.

From Eden to Abraham, from Israel and the prophets to Cornelius, and ultimately to Jesus Christ, the biblical pattern remains consistent: **God reaches out to those who are lost.**

Therefore, when we imagine someone standing before God at the final judgment and saying, **“I genuinely wanted to know You, but You deliberately placed me somewhere where finding You was impossible,”** we are imagining something fundamentally contrary to the biblical story.

We do not need to know precisely how God resolves every conceivable circumstance in order to know that geography will never defeat His ability to seek, reveal, call, or judge rightly.

11. No One at the Great White Throne Will Be Able to Say, “This Is Unfair”

This brings us to something I am personally convinced of concerning the final judgment. **I do not believe a single person who stands before God at the Great White Throne will be able truthfully to say, “This is unfair. You have judged me wrongly. I do not deserve this judgment.”**

Revelation describes that final judgment with extraordinary solemnity:

“And I saw a great white throne and the One seated on it... And I saw the dead, great and small, standing before the throne, and there were open books. And one of them was the Book of Life. And the dead were judged according to their deeds, as recorded in the books.”
— Revelation 20:11–12

The judgment is not portrayed as arbitrary. The books are opened. The dead are judged according to their deeds.

Human courts sometimes condemn innocent people because human judges possess incomplete evidence. Witnesses lie. Evidence is concealed. Motives are misunderstood. Memories fail. Facts remain undiscovered.

None of those limitations will exist at the Great White Throne. The Judge will know every deed, every word, every motive, every opportunity, every rejection of truth, every circumstance into which a person was born, and every measure of revelation that person received.

There will be no missing evidence and no mistaken verdicts.

Paul writes:

“For it is written: ‘As surely as I live, says the Lord, every knee will bow before Me; every tongue will confess to God.’ So then, each of us will give an account of himself to God.”
— Romans 14:11–12

Philippians similarly declares that ultimately *“at the name of Jesus every knee should bow, in heaven and on earth and under the earth, and every tongue confess that Jesus Christ is Lord”* (Philippians 2:10–11).

This writer believes that no condemned person will be able truthfully to protest, “I am innocent,” or “You have judged me unjustly.” The Judge possesses perfect knowledge, and His judgment is perfectly righteous.

Those who are condemned may hate the verdict. They may hate the consequences. They may desperately wish that their lives had been different. **But rejecting a verdict is not the same as being able to demonstrate that the verdict is unjust.**

Paul speaks of “*the day when God will judge men's secrets through Christ Jesus*” (Romans 2:16). What is hidden now will not remain hidden then.

Today we see only fragments. At the Great White Throne, there will be no fragments.

Everything will be known.

No person will be judged unjustly. No person's birthplace, culture, upbringing, knowledge, opportunities, or circumstances will escape the Judge's perfect knowledge.

I am convinced no one will be able truthfully to accuse Him of injustice.

The tragedy of the Great White Throne will not be that God finally rejects people who truly wanted Him. The tragedy will be that the full truth about God, sin, human responsibility, and every person's life will finally stand revealed—and there will be nothing left with which to dispute the righteousness of His judgment.

12. But Doesn't Jesus Say That Most People Will Be Lost?

Jesus' warning in Matthew 7 is sobering:

“Enter through the narrow gate. For wide is the gate and broad is the way that leads to destruction, and many enter through it. But small is the gate and narrow the way that leads to life, and only a few find it.”

— Matthew 7:13–14

We should never explain those words away. Jesus clearly contrasts the **many** who travel the broad way leading to destruction with the **few** who find the narrow way leading to life. Whatever else may be said, Scripture gives us serious reason to believe that many will ultimately be lost—and that those who find eternal life are fewer than those who follow the broad way to destruction.

At the same time, we should not turn Jesus' warning into a mathematical calculation Scripture never provides. The Bible gives us no percentage of all humanity who will ultimately be saved or lost, nor does it authorize us to determine the eternal destiny of particular individuals based upon our limited knowledge of their lives.

And Scripture also gives us another important picture. John's vision of redeemed humanity is staggering:

“After this I looked and saw a multitude too large to count, from every nation and tribe and people and tongue, standing before the throne and before the Lamb.”

— Revelation 7:9

There is no contradiction between these passages. **The redeemed may be fewer than the lost and still constitute a multitude beyond human ability to number.** Revelation does not portray

heaven as occupied by a tiny remnant of humanity. It reveals an immense redeemed people drawn from every nation, tribe, people, and language.

Therefore, Christians should hold both truths together without diminishing either one. Jesus' warning about the broad and narrow ways is real: **many travel the road to destruction. Yet those whom Christ ultimately redeems will form an innumerable multitude gathered from throughout human history and from every corner of the earth.**

13. Would It Have Been Better If God Had Never Created Us?

Now we arrive at perhaps the deepest philosophical question. If even one person is eternally lost, why create a world in which that could happen?

At first the answer might seem obvious: simply don't create. Then nobody suffers, nobody sins, and nobody goes to hell.

But something else is also true. Nobody lives. Nobody loves. Nobody experiences joy or friendship. Nobody knows courage or forgiveness. Nobody experiences redemption. Nobody knows God as Creator, Savior, and Father. There is no redeemed humanity, no resurrection, no new creation, and no countless multitude worshiping before the throne.

There is simply nothing.

But this does not mean that the joy of the redeemed somehow justifies the loss of others, as though God were balancing the eternal happiness of one person against the eternal destruction of another. Christianity does not portray the lost as people sacrificed so that others might enjoy eternal life. **Each person possesses individual moral significance before God, each is responsible for his own response to the truth he has received, and each will be judged individually and with perfect justice.**

The argument is therefore not, “**The happiness of the redeemed makes the loss of others worthwhile.**” The argument is that declaring nonexistence morally superior to God's creation would require knowledge we do not possess. We would have to know the total value of every life, every relationship, every act of love, every redemption, every eternal consequence, and God's ultimate purpose for creation.

We would effectively need God's perspective in order to prove that God chose wrongly.

We do not have that perspective.

14. Could God Have Created a Better World?

Perhaps the objection can be pressed one step further: **If God knew that some of His creatures would reject Him, why did He not simply create a different world—one in which everyone freely chose to love and obey Him?**

At first this seems like an obvious solution. But hidden within the question is a difficult problem.

If God creates genuinely responsible beings who are capable of choosing whether to trust, love, and obey Him, can He at the same time guarantee that every one of those creatures will always freely choose exactly what He desires?

God certainly could have created creatures incapable of rebellion. But that is not the kind of creation Scripture describes. God created beings capable of moral responsibility, genuine obedience, and genuine rebellion.

We should also distinguish between **imagining** a world in which every person freely chooses God and demonstrating that God could **actualize** such a world while preserving those genuinely free choices. Those are not necessarily the same thing.

It is easy for us to imagine a world in which Adam never ate the forbidden fruit, Lucifer never rebelled, and every human being freely chose to love and obey God. But imagining such a world does not demonstrate that God could guarantee that outcome while at the same time allowing His creatures to make genuinely free moral choices.

If the choices are genuinely free, then the creatures themselves are responsible for making them. God may know beforehand exactly what they will choose, and He may still accomplish His purposes through those choices, but **knowing what someone will choose is not the same as making the choice for them. Allowing someone to choose is not the same as causing them to choose.**

Therefore, the statement, **“God could simply have created a world in which everyone freely chose Him,”** contains an assumption that must itself be demonstrated. It assumes that God could guarantee what every free creature would choose without altering the very freedom being appealed to.

We should be careful not to claim more than Scripture reveals. Scripture does not tell us whether God could have created a different world in which every person freely chose Him. But neither does it give us any basis for assuming that such a world was actually possible while preserving genuine creaturely freedom. **To insist that God could have done so is to claim knowledge of possibilities known fully only to God.**

The limits of our knowledge therefore cut both ways. We cannot claim to know everything God could have created—but neither can we condemn God for failing to create an alternative world that we cannot establish was ever truly possible.

And Scripture gives us an important reason not to assume that rebellion resulted merely from a defective human environment.

Rebellion was not limited to humanity.

Scripture reveals rebellion among angelic beings as well as among human beings. Whatever we may not know about the precise chronology and circumstances of that rebellion, one fact is significant: rebellion occurred among beings whose knowledge of God's reality was vastly greater than ours.

That tells us something important:

Greater revelation does not guarantee love. Direct knowledge of God's reality does not make rebellion impossible.

We see the same principle in Eden. Adam and Eve were not born into a fallen world or surrounded by centuries of religious confusion. They lived in a creation God Himself pronounced “*very good*” (Genesis 1:31). They experienced God's provision and knew His command.

Yet they rebelled.

The problem therefore cannot simply be blamed upon environment, insufficient evidence, or unequal religious opportunity. Rebellion reaches deeper. Scripture locates the problem within the creature.

A further objection might be raised: **If the redeemed will live forever in the New Creation without rebelling against God, why could God not simply have created humanity in that condition from the beginning?**

The important distinction is that **glorified humanity is not simply innocent humanity restored to Eden. The redeemed are not merely innocent human beings placed into a perfect environment. They are a redeemed and transformed people brought through the history of sin, grace, redemption, resurrection, and ultimately glorification.** Scripture says that when Christ appears, “*we will be like Him*” (1 John 3:2), and that what is raised will be “*imperishable*” and “*in glory*” (1 Corinthians 15:42–43).

Could God simply have begun with glorified humanity and still accomplished everything He intends through creation and redemption? **Scripture does not tell us.** The fact that redeemed humanity will one day live without sin does not prove that God could simply have started there and still accomplished everything He intended through the *Scarlet Thread of Redemption*.

Could God have prevented all of this? Certainly. He could have chosen not to create at all. He could have prevented the possibility of creaturely rebellion by not creating beings capable of rejecting Him. And after rebellion occurred, He could have immediately ended the story.

But He did none of those things. Instead, God created knowing rebellion would occur and knowing what redemption would cost Him.

Why did God consider a creation containing freedom, rebellion, redemption, judgment, resurrection, and ultimately a new creation worth bringing into existence?

Scripture does not give us the complete answer.

But it does give us the end of the story.

God's purpose is not merely to restore humanity to Eden. Revelation ends with something greater: a redeemed people from every nation, tribe, people, and tongue dwelling forever in the presence of God. Sin is judged. Death is destroyed. Evil is defeated. Creation is made new. And those who belong to God know Him not merely as Creator, but as Redeemer.

Scripture tells us something arguably more important:

He knew rebellion would come. He knew what redemption would cost. He knew the end from the beginning.

Yet He chose to create.

15. God Did Not Remain Outside Human Suffering

Christianity's most powerful response to the problem of suffering is not ultimately philosophical. It is historical and personal:

Jesus Christ.

God did not create a suffering world and remain untouched by it. According to Christianity, God entered it. Jesus knew hunger, exhaustion, temptation, rejection, betrayal, and grief. He wept at a grave. He was falsely accused, beaten, mocked, crucified, and died.

Whatever answer Christianity gives to human suffering must pass through the cross. At the cross God does not explain suffering from a safe distance.

He enters it.

But the cross reveals more than God's participation in human suffering. It reveals what God did about human guilt. Human beings rebel against God. Justice demands judgment. Yet God Himself provides the sacrifice.

Paul writes:

“God proves His love for us in this: While we were still sinners, Christ died for us.”
— Romans 5:8

The cross therefore prevents us from picturing God as casually condemning creatures whose fate costs Him nothing. **The Judge bears the judgment.** Whatever mysteries remain concerning

God's decision to create, Calvary reveals something essential about the character of the One who made that decision.

16. Hell Must Be Viewed Through the Cross

If the cross reveals what kind of God judges humanity, then it must also shape how we think about hell.

If we speak of judgment without speaking of Calvary, we can easily create a distorted picture of God—as though He created humanity knowing many would be lost and then remained indifferent to their fate.

The cross will not allow that picture.

Jesus did not merely warn humanity about judgment. He came to rescue humanity from it:

“For God did not send His Son into the world to condemn the world, but to save the world through Him.”

— John 3:17

The cross therefore reveals two truths at the same time. First, sin is far more serious than we often imagine. If reconciliation between sinful humanity and a holy God required the death of Jesus Christ, sin cannot simply be dismissed as though it does not matter.

But the cross also reveals the extraordinary extent of God's desire to save. The God who judges sin is the God who provided the sacrifice for sinners.

Christianity therefore tells a very different story from one in which humanity must somehow find its own way back to God.

Humanity rebelled. **God came after us.** Humanity incurred judgment. **God provided the sacrifice.** Humanity could not remove its own guilt. **Christ bore our sin.**

This is why the question cannot merely be, “**How can a loving God judge sinners?**” We must also ask, “**What has this loving God done to save sinners from judgment?**”

Christianity's answer is extraordinary:

He gave Himself.

At this point, an observation by C. S. Lewis provides a helpful philosophical and theological illustration. Lewis argued that final separation from God should not be pictured merely as God arbitrarily casting away people who desperately wanted Him. Rather, judgment may also be understood, at least in part, as the final consequence of a creature's persistent refusal of God.

In *The Great Divorce*, Lewis memorably distinguished between those who finally say to God, **“Thy will be done,”** and those to whom God ultimately says, in effect, **“thy will be done.”**

That thought finds a striking parallel in the biblical pattern we have already seen: Christ longs to gather those who are unwilling to come (Matthew 23:37). John adds:

“The Light has come into the world, but men loved the darkness rather than the Light because their deeds were evil.”
— John 3:19

Paul similarly describes humanity as suppressing the truth about God and repeatedly says that God **“gave them over”** to the course they had chosen (Romans 1:18, 24, 26, 28).

Taken together, these passages reveal a sobering pattern: **God reveals, calls, warns, seeks, and offers mercy, while human beings can resist, suppress, refuse, and turn away.**

This does not mean that every unbeliever consciously says, *“I reject God and choose hell.”* Human unbelief is far more complicated than that. As we have already seen, upbringing, culture, knowledge, deception, and opportunity all matter, and God alone knows perfectly how those factors bear upon each individual.

But **God's final judgment should not be imagined as the arbitrary rejection of people who genuinely desired reconciliation with Him while He refused to receive them.**

That picture does not fit the God revealed in Scripture.

The biblical picture is of a God who says, **“Turn and live,”** who sends His Son **“to seek and to save the lost,”** and who ultimately gives Himself upon the cross for sinners.

Hell should therefore never be preached with delight, arrogance, or satisfaction over the fate of another human being. Hell is real because sin and judgment are real. But the cross prevents us from concluding that judgment means God is indifferent to those who perish.

There we see both truths at once:

God takes sin seriously enough to judge it.

And God loves sinners enough to bear its cost Himself.

Any understanding of hell that forgets that truth has forgotten something essential about the God revealed in Jesus Christ.

17. The Bible's Story Does Not End with Hell

If we summarize Christianity as **Creation → Fall → most people go to hell**, we have badly distorted the biblical story.

The Bible's story is:

Creation → Fall → Redemption → Resurrection → Judgment → New Creation.

Revelation contains terrible judgment, but judgment is not the final picture John gives us. The final vision is:

“Behold, the dwelling place of God is with man.”
— Revelation 21:3

Then comes one of the most beautiful promises in Scripture:

“He will wipe away every tear from their eyes, and there will be no more death or mourning or crying or pain, for the former things have passed away.”
— Revelation 21:4

And the One seated upon the throne declares:

“Behold, I make all things new.”
— Revelation 21:5

That is where the biblical story is going—not toward Satan's victory, evil's victory, or death's victory.

But toward restoration.

18. Perhaps the Greatest Question Is Not “Why Did God Create?” but “What Is God Creating?”

We naturally view creation from our present location, and from here we see enormous suffering. But Scripture views history from eternity.

Paul makes an astonishing statement:

“I consider that our present sufferings are not comparable to the glory that will be revealed in us.”
— Romans 8:18

That does not make present suffering imaginary. Paul knew suffering intimately. He was beaten, imprisoned, persecuted, and eventually faced death. Yet he believed the completed work of God would be so extraordinary that present suffering could not finally be compared with the glory to come.

Paul then widens the picture beyond human redemption to creation itself. He says that creation was subjected to futility in hope:

“that the creation itself will be set free from its bondage to decay and brought into the glorious freedom of the children of God.”

— Romans 8:21

The present condition of creation, therefore, is not its final condition. The world we see around us—marked by death, decay, suffering, and corruption—is a creation awaiting liberation.

Perhaps, then, we cannot completely evaluate God's decision to create while standing in the unfinished middle of the story. We have not seen resurrection. We have not seen evil finally destroyed. We have not seen creation liberated from corruption. We have not seen humanity glorified. We have not seen the New Jerusalem. We have not seen what eternity with God actually means.

We are attempting to judge the completed work while standing inside an unfinished chapter.

19. The Question Finally Comes Down to Whether God Can Be Trusted

Eventually all these questions converge on one issue:

What kind of God is He?

If God is cruel, then His sovereignty should terrify us. If God is arbitrary, then His judgment cannot be trusted. If God is indifferent, then human suffering becomes almost impossible to reconcile with creation.

But Christianity makes a radically different claim. It says the God who created us is the God revealed in Jesus Christ.

Jesus said:

“Anyone who has seen Me has seen the Father.”

— John 14:9

Therefore, if we want to know what the Creator is like, Christianity points us to Christ. Look at Him touching lepers, receiving sinners, weeping beside Lazarus' tomb, forgiving His enemies, welcoming children, confronting hypocrisy, and defending the helpless.

And finally:

Look at Him on the cross.

That is Christianity's answer to the accusation that God does not care what happens to humanity.

After all the arguments have been considered, therefore, I would ask the skeptic one question:

If you became convinced that God is perfectly good, perfectly just, perfectly loving, and that no human being will ever be treated unfairly by Him, would you trust Him even if you still could not understand every reason He chose to create this world?

Christianity does not ask us to place our trust in an unknown character. **It asks us to look at Jesus Christ.**

Conclusion — The Cross Gives Us Reason to Trust What We Cannot Yet Understand

Why did God create humanity knowing that humanity would fall? Why create people He knew would reject Him? Why permit rebellion and centuries of suffering? Why are people born into radically different religious circumstances? Why does one person hear the gospel repeatedly while another seemingly hears almost nothing? Why did God choose this world rather than another?

This paper has attempted to establish something extremely important: **the biblical evidence does not reveal a God who created carelessly, arbitrarily, or because He delights in human destruction.** It reveals a God who knew the cost of creation, calls sinners to turn and live, seeks the lost, entered the suffering of His creation, bore the cost of redemption Himself, and promises ultimately to judge every human being with perfect righteousness.

We know that God created humanity intentionally. We know that humanity rebelled. We know God's sovereignty and foreknowledge did not make human rebellion morally innocent. We know God's revealed desire is that sinners repent rather than perish. We know people receive differing measures of revelation and that God takes their knowledge and circumstances into account in His judgment. We know salvation comes through Jesus Christ. We know God judges with knowledge infinitely greater than ours. And we know the redeemed will ultimately include a multitude from every nation, tribe, people, and language that no one can number.

And above everything else, we know that the God who created a world in which suffering would occur did not exempt Himself from that suffering.

He entered it.

The Creator became part of His creation. The immortal One tasted death. The Judge stood in the place of the guilty. The innocent One bore the sins of the guilty. And the God whom humanity rejected opened the way for humanity to return to Him.

Here we must remember something essential to the Christian message: **none of us deserves eternal life with God.** Scripture declares, **“There is no one righteous, not even one”** (Romans 3:10), and **“all have sinned and fall short of the glory of God”** (Romans 3:23). Heaven is not a reward God owes to good people while unjustly withholding it from others. **Everyone who**

enters Heaven's gate will be there only because of the mercy and grace of God through Jesus Christ. Salvation is not something we earn, deserve, or can demand. It is a gift purchased for the guilty by the One who was innocent.

There are things about God's eternal purposes I do not understand, and questions about eternity that Scripture has not answered to our complete satisfaction. But after everything we have considered, the question finally becomes not whether I can understand every purpose of God, but whether I have sufficient reason to trust the character of God.

Christianity points us to Jesus Christ.

We are not being asked to trust an unseen deity whose character is completely unknown. We are being asked to trust the God who has revealed Himself in **Jesus Christ—the fulfillment of the *Scarlet Thread of Redemption***—the One who entered our world, shared our suffering, bore our sin, died in our place, and opened the way to eternal life.

Praise God, He has revealed all we need to know in order to trust Him.

The cross gives me reason to trust the character of God when I cannot fully comprehend all the purposes of God.

And perhaps that is where this difficult question finally leads—not to an explanation of every mystery, but to the wounded hands of the One who knew what creation would cost—

and created us anyway.